# Bells Echoing in the Valley

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# Prologue: Last Echoes in the Forest

COL-307201

...

The wind tears at what's left of his clothes. His body is like a hunk of naked flesh, crawling miserably along.

The scarred chest and the bloodied feet have numbed him, but he keeps his hollowed eyes fixed on the steep, terrifying road ahead.

??? : Keep moving, to the higher place ...

He mumbles through cracked lips.

Where is here? None could tell, but the man knows he must go north, away from that village, away from that city, and into the rumored depths to find his final salvation.

By now he has successfully distanced himself from his homeland.

But he does not know if he will make it, or if he will become a feast for the vultures.

The physical agony and torment let him temporarily escape the mental torture. To him, this is enough.

He does not want the journey to end. Instead, he wants the penance to go on ceaselessly, like the fierce wind swirling on the cliff.

??? : This is...

The uneven ground ends, and a dense forest lies ahead.

Birds hop high above in the treetops. He hears a faint rustling from the bushes and the gurgling of melting ice water.

??? : Water...!

He buries his head in the icy river, the cold making his skull tremble, and rejoices with deep gulps.

Shamane: ...Ahhhh!

Having guzzled down the water, he lies on the soft moss, gazing at the dreary sky.

Shamane: Let's see how much farther you can take me.

He digs out the sharp pebbles in his soles, tears off his left arm cloth to bandage the wound, and walks to the forest entrance.

A huge tree towers over the entrance.

The bark is peeled off, carved with a twisted, bizarre deity.

The deity's face is smeared with beast blood, seemingly warning those about to enter the forest.

A hand full of wounds is placed on it.

Shamane: After all, the poisoned arrows, deadly traps, and fierce animals...

Fingers without nails brush over the deity's eyes.

Shamane: This face even looks welcoming to me, my friend.

He raises his hand, snaps off a thick branch, and staggers into the lush forest.

# River

COL-307202

The river splits the land in two, like a crack in a canyon, turbulent and icy, never to be mended.

Without a doubt, the rapids will sweep away anything that steps into the current. While the remains will become a feast for the fishes, continuing to nourish this forest.

Shamane: Hm...

Shamane: It's not wise to wade this river.

He looks at the river's source and its destination, with no end in sight.

Crouching down, he reaches his right hand into the rapids, feeling its breath and fury. But he frowns solemnly, withdrawing his hand.

Shamane: Seems like I'm not welcome here, either.

Bowing his head, he looks back at the way he came.

After a long while, he turns and faces the river, taking a deep breath.

—Splash! He jumps in without hesitation.

...

...

Shamane: Blech! Cough cough cough...

Shamane: Washed ashore on the other side, he kneels on the ground, convulsing and vomiting.

Shamane: Ah... Ah... Choo!

Shamane: ...

Shamane: Just walk it off if you still can. Nothing to complain about.

# Giant Rock

COL-307203

Where did it come from? And how did it end up here?

Massive, immovable—anyone who sets their eyes on it would wonder about these things.

The huge boulder, carved with strange patterns, is wedged in the crevice by accident or not, blocking the only way forward.

It remains motionless, leaving only a gap the size of a fist.

Shamane: ...It looks a bit taller than the sacred fig tree at home.

He pats the rock. Its smooth touch seems especially unfriendly now.

Shamane: Hmm...it's not as easy to climb as that tree!

He looks for footholds on the boulder and moves up it skillfully, climbing bit by bit with his right hand.

Shamane: Phew, phew...good...Ah-!

The boulder below suddenly begins to shake.

Along with the strange movement, the patterns on the boulder emit light.

Shamane: !?...!

The boulder's shaking intensifies, until it jolts and throws him off violently.

On the ground, a cone-shaped bone shard stands sharp, predictably piercing his calf.

Shamane: Ugh...!

Blood soaks the leg cloth.

Shamane: Tsk... How is this rock...

An unforeseen obstacle.

Bearing the pain, he forcibly digs out the bone shard.

Shamane: Phew...quite the temper.

# Bramble Bushes

COL-307204

He probes carefully, leaving a drop of blood on his fingertip from the thorns.

Shamane: ...

The blood-red thorns have grown rampant. Within the thicket, numerous skeletons can be seen intact; the blood-soaked soil has turned dark crimson—this seems to be its sustenance.

Shamane: Seems like you've been feasting in the past years.

The fingers avoid the tips, instead grabbing the coarse branches between the spines.

Shamane: I wonder what your teeth can do to the stones, if they couldn't even break up human bones?

Shamane: ...Let me think...

He gathers a pile of pebbles, picking out the hardest and sharpest rocks.

Shamane: Ha-!

The rock held high crashes down on the thorns, shattering sections of branches. Bright red sap splatters on his arms in a speckled pattern.

Shamane: Huff— Huff—

Shamane: Almost done.

The thorns on their last legs, Shamane reaches in with his stick, prying open the broken thorns, and squeezing in sideways with his body.

But the thorns seem to sense the foreign intrusion and swarms around, their hooks piercing his ankles, abdomen, and aiming for his eyes...

Shamane: ...!

The lone right hand grips the climbing branches tightly.

Shamane: At the very least...

Shamane: I can't stop here!

The spikes pierce deep into the skin.

Shamane: —!!

He moves forward, disappearing into the thorn bushes.

# Epilogue: Last Echoes in the Forest

COL-307205

Shamane: Whew...

After a day's bitter journey, his exhausted, battered body finally reaches a quiet place.

The scabbed wounds ache faintly. He swallows a mouthful of bloody saliva, trying to deceive his howling stomach.

Shamane: Nearly there.

He looks up, the sky spinning in his eyes.

Shamane: ...

Without any warning, his heavy eyelids droop—the sky draws its curtain.

Freezing darkness swallows the hills, invading his body, and soon his consciousness sinks into a dense darkness.

He collapses to the ground like a cut log. The faint sounds quickly are dispersed by the wind and snow, disappearing into the woods.

3#1

# Prologue: Reduced to Ashes

COL-307206

He vaguely hears a woman crying helplessly. The sound of her trembling vocal cords is familiar...

The smell of burning wood rushes into his nose, and he hears a crackling sound beside his ears...

Shamane: ...!

Shamane: This again.

He sees flames ablaze, engulfing the house before him, black debris floating before his eyes.

He stands before the dilapidated house, shadows covering his face, a sense of suffocation like the day the fire started.

Shamane: I won't fall for this again. I will stand here and watch you burn to ashes.

Shamane: Ugh...

"What if this is real?" A voice whispers to him.

Shamane: ...

The same voice, to which he once sacrificed his left arm in a state of despair.

Thus Mor Pankh was spared, but the powerful Sharma was no more in this world.

"You can still make a choice..."

The wooden door in the house collapses, sparks splashing on his face, painful, scalding, then doused by tears.

Sweat streams down his dirty face and he clenches his fists.

"This may be the last chance, you know."

"You try to abandon it all. To forget everything and numb yourself with physical pain, but the meaningless questions still swirl endlessly in your head."

"But is it really meaningless?"

# Father

COL-307207

He used to look down on the family, disregarding his mission and wasting his outstanding talents.

A veritable Eden, where arcanists and humans could coexist without hierarchy. That should be the shared future worth pursuing.

...He had never wavered in this belief.

Shamane: Father...

The crippled man supports himself on the table, sits on the floor and leans against the wall.

The burning wood crashes down thunderously, shattering the table inches away. But the man is indifferent.

Kullu: Kapil, you d*****s! This isn't what we agreed to. Look at this fire, it's reaching our house!

Kapil: I... I've no idea. Weren't we supposed to throw all the bottles out?...

Kullu: D****t, those guys didn't tell us any of this! Forget it, let's run!

They stand in front of the gate, as if watching a circus act gone wrong.

"These are your trusted human friends, good child." His father's voice echoed in his mind.

Shamane: ...

The guilt and grief have subsided over time.

Only the deep-rooted hatred remains.

He goes over and tries to support the old man on the ground, as he had done time and again in his nightmares.

Shamane's Father: We don't need you here.

Rejected once again. His father's dignity and grace didn't fade in his memory, even after his death.

Shamane's Father: You are no longer a Sharma... Take your hands off me.

Shamane: Father...

Shamane's Father: ... Your mother and I, the entire family have invested years in your education ...

Shamane's Father: Yet you have let us down ... You are in no position to make any decision for this family.

Before this, even when he was estranged from the clan, they never doubted him. Rather, they saw him as a wayward child.

Shamane's Father: You think our reluctance to interact with humans is just stubbornness.

Shamane's Father: You think we shut those humans out to cling to our land, intimidated, and afraid of losing this so-called dignity.

Shamane's Father: Pushya, human friendship has blinded you. Yet, we have tolerated your childish ignorance many times.

Shamane's Father: We always hoped you would turn back and understand it is not so simple—that this is not a rift you alone can mend...

He shakes his head, his last bit of strength spent.

His throat chokes up as he tries to utter those undelivered words.

Shamane: I ... I can give everything back to you, as long as everyone gets out of this place ...

"Slap!"

Shamane's Father: Out!

"Hiss."

Without looking up, a broken beam falls across his eyes.

Blood flows on the ground, mirroring the recurring scene from the nightmares that have haunted him since that day.

# Mother

COL-307208

The hall becomes a sea of flames, and in the crackling and sputtering elegy of the fire, he hears a woman's prayer.

Her voice is terribly familiar, reminding you of the lullabies that accompanied you through every punished night of your childhood.

Kicking open the locked door, he sees the servants lying on the ground.

Shamane: Come, mama. I can carry you out...

Shamane's Mother: "The white elephant will look after your soul, and place you on a bed of warmth, where you shall attain eternal serenity."

She clasps the servant's hand, granting him final peace.

Shamane's Mother: Bhagat finds the arsonists in the backyard and vows to stop them.

Shamane's Mother: But they came prepared —those Molotov cocktails and weapons are not the likes you've seen before. It must be that group's bidding... These are things humans can't normally access.

Shamane: Who are they?! Mother, tell me...

Mother closes her eyes, shaking her head.

Blood keeps gushing from the servant's neck.

Shamane's Mother: ...Bhagat always told me that this is not your fault.

Shamane's Mother: I said I understand. I know that you've always been a good child.

Her frail pale hands are drenched in blood.

Shamane: Sorry, I'm sorry. I... I didn't know they would do this. There wasn't any... They never told me...

But his mother speaks no more. No matter how he tries, her body remains still.

He looks around for ways to extinguish the flames. Turning back, a figure stands in the courtyard.

He strides over in disbelief, stumbling.

# Kumar

COL-307209

The burning sacred fig tree, the collapsing houses... She watches it all with delight, as if enjoying it.

Shamane: Sis... Sister?

Shamane: Why are you here?

Kumar: Oh, now you see me as your sister ... And calling me like you had always known.

Kumar: I remember you were—this tall.

Kumar: She casually gestures around her thigh.

Shamane: ...What?

Kumar: The day the manor gates closed before my eyes.

Kumar: Hmm...was this sacred fig tree so tall before?

Kumar: ...As for why I'm here, you should know best.

Shamane: ...!

Kumar: You know I had nothing to do with this—but you think I'd enjoy it, so you let me into your head to watch...right?

Kumar: Hmm...well done. You do know me after all.

She caresses the charred bark, indifferent to it all.

Shamane: ...

Kumar: Don't look at me like that—they want you to save them. I'm just an insignificant...arcanist wielding shoddy skills.

As the words leave her lips, flames erupt once more, consuming the last pillar of the manor.

Shamane: ...!?

# Epilogue: Reduced to Ashes

COL-307210

"You've come again."

Nothingness, shrouded in a veil of mist, a pure and unblemished white space.

Shamane: Where am I?

"That's unimportant."

Shamane: You dragged me into a nightmare again?

"Your soul always longs to return."

A white elephant emerges from the mist, standing before him, solemn and dignified.

Shamane: It's you...!!

Shamane: What else will you take besides my arm?

Shamane: Come take it! Besides this body, I have nothing left to give you.

"..."

Its figure slowly fades away.

...

...

3#1

# Prologue: Fangs and Fists

COL-307211

Intense pain awakens his consciousness from the chaos.

Flames, the elephant...they're just illusions—

Shamane: Ugh...!

His aching abdomen... The herbal paste on the wound gives off a pungent smell.

Shamane: ...?

He sits up. Animal bones hang on the walls, the rough wooden table and shelves...filled with all kinds of jars.

A mask hangs from ropes at the center of the house. Its face is fierce, showing unquestionable authority.

Shamane: ...!

Shamane: Now ... I am on the right track.

A note is weighed down by a rock on the chair.

"Close the door."

Shamane: Hah-hah...

The owner isn't a warm-hearted fellow then.

But rejection is never the issue... All he has left now is patience.

He gets up and pushes open the creaking door, stepping across the threshold—he needs to quell his hunger first before the owner returns.

# Goat Herd

COL-307212

The stream flows steadily as a group of Tahrs drink by the water. They look docile and clumsy—not alert in the slightest.

Shamane: Okay.

He tries hard to ignore the pangs of hunger tormenting his stomach. The dagger turns lightly in his palm, and his footsteps grow more cautious.

Shamane: Shh...Please, keep drinking...

A muskox abruptly looks up, its eyes meeting his. The shining dagger reflects in its slanted pupil.

...

Shamane: D**n!

Like a snapped line, it scurries away in panic.

The other musks respond to the escape call, running away one after another. In a flash, Shamane stands alone on the plains, like a lone sprig.

Shamane: *sigh*...

He sits on a rock, heaving a long sigh.

# Stone Circle: One

COL-307213

He washes his grimy face, the icy water sobering him a little more.

If he goes deeper into the forest, perhaps he can fill his belly with some berries—if lucky, he may still get to prepare a meeting gift for that mysterious old shaman.

Shamane: "Grace repays grace"...

Shamane: ...One of the few useful teachings the clan left me.

He casually picks up some pebbles and stuffs them in his pocket to keep the beasts away and knock berries off trees.

Shamane: —Hmm?

He frowns, keeping his distance, the pebbles on the ground arranged in a pattern like a spell.

Shamane: What...is this...

It's no longer intact because of his disruption.

Shamane: It looks like—

Shamane: Owww—! What?

He looks down and sees a furry carbuncle biting his thigh.

Shamane: ...? Just where did you come from?

He lifts his leg, swinging hard. The carbuncle flies midair like a fallen fledgling, crashing heavily into the soft soil.

Carbuncle: %@#!

Shamane holds it up to his face, examining the tiny strange creature.

Suddenly, it quiets down, grinning meaningfully. Shamane turns his head—a group of carbuncles is charging ferociously towards him.

Carbuncles: %@#! %@#!

Shamane: Do we have to do this, little one?

Shamane: Shall we make a deal?

The squeezed carbuncle stares silently, seeming unwilling to let him go...

Shamane: ...Fine.

# [English text unavailable]

COL-307214

A fierce battle ends...The furball jumps onto the fallen body, crawling up Shamane's back to his nape.

It lifts its head, grabbing a branch in its mouth, proudly proclaiming this great victory. The carbuncles below crowd together, hopping about. It's a grand furry event, to be recorded in their history.

After each carbuncle leaves a footprint on him, the festivities finally come to an end...

Shamane: ...

Shamane: Sigh, I should be used to this...

Getting up, he brushes the mud off, his empty stomach hastening his steps.

It's not time to stop yet, but he knows his exhausted body can't face any more turmoil.

# Stone Circle: Two

COL-307215

A fierce battle ends...with the carbuncles scattering away in leaps and bounds. Only one furball remains in place.

It trembles all over, yet still stands tall before Shamane.

Shamane: ...

Expressionless, Shamane raises a branch towards the furball, his long shadow falling over it, its fur drenched in fear.

The branch swings down but lands elsewhere. Unable to withstand the fear, the furball scurries away whimpering.

Dropping the branch, he brushes the mud off, his empty stomach hastening his steps.

It's not time to stop yet, but he knows his exhausted body can't face any more turmoil.

# Berries

COL-307216

Forests always nest packs of wolves.

Berries were scattered around, but it was him they were eyeing, baring fangs, growling low, and clearly unwilling to let him leave.

Shamane: Come on then, try me, friends.

Of course, he can't fight the wolf pack.

But right now, retreating and advancing are equally dangerous—bluffing is also a philosophy of survival.

Shamane: I will cut your one belly open before you pierce my neck with those teeth and suck up my blood.

The alpha approaches step by step, the rest of the pack following far behind.

Shamane: He takes out his dagger, legs instinctively in a battle stance.

**Choices**

1. An opportunity!

He steps back, breaking into a run, rushing into the woods.

The sound of the wolves' pursuit is relentless, trailing closely behind...

# Epilogue: Fangs and Fists

COL-307217

This is the end.

Below the towering cliff, lies a turbulent, narrow river. Vultures circle above, awaiting fresh corpses.

He has nowhere left to retreat.

The wolf pack halts. For this imminent meal, what they have to consider now is how to obtain it...with the fewest losses...

Shamane: ...

He closes his eyes, nostrils contracting as he inhales.

Shamane: If it can stop here...

The pack attacks, but he releases the dagger in hand. Now any one of their claws can tear his body apart.

??? : Phwwhht—!

A whistle sounds and the wolves pause, quickly retreating back to their original spots.

A hunchbacked figure strides out of the forest, casually throwing the wolves some rotten meat. The alpha takes the meat, leaving silently with the rest of the pack.

Shaman: Heh ...

He turns his head slightly, his gaze sliding past the dagger on the ground and glancing at the figure standing at the edge of the cliff before heading into the forest without looking back.

Shamane watches the hunchbacked figure leave further and further. Finally snapping out of shock, he jogs to catch up.

3#1

# Prologue: In Humility

COL-307218

Although hunchbacked, the old man's steps are much faster than his.

He moves casually through the shady, lush forest, as if walking through his backyard garden.

Shamane: Hah... hah...

Shamane drags his battered body, scrambling to chase after the hunchbacked man.

Shamane: It was you who helped me.

The certainty in his words declares it no question.

Shaman: ...

The old man ignores the youth's words, as silent as ever. His footsteps remain the same, seemingly oblivious to the panting growing heavier behind him.

Until he seems to notice something, stopping in his tracks.

An injured vulture lies on the ground, its pecked eyes bloody.

Shamane: Ah!

Shamane looks over the old man's shoulder, seeing the holes in the vulture's skull.

Shamane: ...

This is inappropriate, nor is it delicacy. It's all just instinct—and the shame that instinct brings, makes his cheeks flush.

Shamane: Ahem...I...

The old man pays no mind to you. He reaches out his rough, bark-like hand, gently stroking the vulture. It trembles no more, pupils gazing up at him, as if looking upon a deity.

Finally, the calmness of death descends, accompanied by flies, and he too leaves.

Shamane: ...

The two continue walking in silence, one after another.

# Shaman: One

COL-307219

By the stone formation in the gully, a familiar silhouette sways lightly.

Its black fluff bristles slightly—it's on alert.

Shamane: Hm?

Shamane: Ah, it's the one from before...

The old man walks straight towards it.

The furball bounces over and you see him bow slightly, placing a bunch of purple flowers on the formation.

Carbuncle: @#$%!

The tiny carbuncle happily hops, gladly making way.

Shaman: Hehe...

The old man shakes his head, flashing a light smile, and steps over the cleared path.

The carbuncle dutifully returns to its original spot, continuing its alert glances...

Shamane: ...

# Carbuncle

COL-307220

The furry thing smells Shamane from afar.

Without a word, it bites down on Shamane's calf familiarly.

Shamane: ...

Shamane: Fine...I should have been more courteous...

He opens his palm—the little purple flowers drenched in blood and sweat, wrinkled beyond recognition, lifeless like the one who picked them.

Carbuncle: ...?

Shamane: I saw he had...something like this. Sorry they got all...

He tilts his body slightly and raises his left shoulder.

Carbuncle: @#$%!...

It releases its mouth, looking somewhat dissatisfied.

Carbuncle: @#$%!

But it's generous with him.

The carbuncle reluctantly moves aside.

Shamane: ...Thank you.

Shamane: You have done your part dutifully.

He places the new adornment on the formation and catches up to the old man in the distance.

The furball gazes at him as his silhouette grows smaller and smaller...

# Goat Herd

COL-307221

They paw away rocks, chewing the tender grass underneath.

Without the noise of water, the Tahr's ears are especially keen. The slightest wind can make them alert.

Shaman: Twee-twee—...

The long whistle pierces through the woods, gullies, and streams, echoing across the deep mountains.

The herd suddenly lifts their heads as one, looking at the old man above them, like a flock of loyal disciples.

The old man jumps down, and the herd abandons the delicious tender grass below, scurrying after him.

**Choices**

1. Join the herd
2. Follow the herd from behind

**Branch 1**

The man tries to blend into the herd, becoming one of the disciples.

A stray lamb stops, looking at him with a hint of confusion.

Shamane: Uh, am I bothering you?

The lamb shakes its hooves, lifting its head—how effacing, letting the weak go first.

Shamane: ...

The youngster helplessly drops a shoulder, continuing to trudge between the sheep hooves.

The arrogant little lamb follows behind him—disciples will be disciples.

**Branch 2**

Shamane follows behind the sheep, observing a staggering lamb at his feet.

It struggles to keep up, stumbling and falling behind.

Reaching out his right hand, he gently carries the lamb overhead, squeezing into the herd.

# Shaman: Two

COL-307222

The wolf pack lies between the rocks, not baring fangs or claws.

Alpha wolf: ...

The alpha straightens up, looking straight at the approaching old man.

Shaman: ...

The old man's steps happen to stop not far from the pack.

He slowly takes another step, as if breaking some boundary, and the alpha swiftly baring fangs, arching its back.

Shaman: ...

Shaman: Hmm... I need to ask you to leave for a bit.

The old man takes out a rope-like object, folding the small pouch on it. Putting in a stone, he swings his wrist.

"Clack!"

The rock shoots towards the pack, leaving an indent on the tree trunk behind them.

Hearing the sound, the alpha's erect ears tilt back slightly.

It twitches its nose, hesitating for a moment, and then leads the pack to retreat to the side of the rocks.

The old man picks up the stone, sighing.

His unforgiving silhouette keeps moving, hands clasped behind his back as he gradually walks away.

Shamane catches up, but the pack quickly scurries back. Baring their blood-red gums, clearly hostile.

With your fragile fists? Or... Perhaps you can find another way?

# Pavia

COL-307224

Tree branches, sheep wool...he cobbles them together into a crude slingshot.

Shamane: ...Here's hoping this bluff works.

Grabbing a pebble, he places it in the leaf pouch and tries swinging it like the old man...

Shamane: Hah!

The pebble flies high! Before it even lands, the alpha makes way and the wolves scatter.

But the pebble hits nothing, flying endlessly, falling who knows where...

Shamane: Hah, I looked like that too when I saw the fire.

Shamane: ...

Shamane: The fear... Well I can't take credit for that.

The path opens, like an outstretched hand.

# Epilogue: In Humility

COL-307225

Shamane: Almost there...

He can already vaguely see the outline of the cabin.

His body is still panging with hunger. Another fruitless day.

Fruitless... Every day is fruitless.

Shamane: ...At least this time, I remembered to close the door.

He doesn't know why he's back here again—he has no home.

Shamane: But...what if...could it be?

He's ashamed to still be alive, but he's come this far—all in search of life's answer.

The blurry outline ahead becomes clearer.

Shamane sees the old man standing at the door of the cabin, gazing down at him and the forest behind him.

Shamane: ...

He stops.

The old man turns and enters the cabin.

Yet the door remains open.

Shamane: ...!

His troubled thoughts dissipate, and he quickened his steps up the steep slope.

3#1

# Prologue: It Rains the Same Old Rain

COL-307226

Autumn winds batter the door, the fire quietly burning, gathering warmth.

Inside, a bed has been conspicuously added, the hanging masks knocking into each other with a dull clinking sound.

Shamane: Hm...

In the house, the man twirls his dagger nimbly around the deer's neck, instantly slitting its throat open perfectly.

Shamane: ♪...Not bad.

The blade gently cuts between the muscles and fur, and in no time, with the crisp sound of the dagger dropping, the whole deer skin is neatly peeled off.

The blood-soaked right hand gently picks up the deerskin. He tilts his head, stepping on the skin's end with his right foot, proudly appreciating the unfurled work in hand.

Shamane: Phew! Looks like this little guy will make a good drum skin.

Shamane: Let's see...what the old man wants today—

He releases his right foot pulling the deerskin, and uses his relatively clean toes to pinch the note lying slightly out of reach.

Shamane: Hmmm...Mhmm...

Shamane: ...

Shamane: This old guy's serious?!

He bolts up, nearly punching a hole in the ceiling.

Startled, the magpies behind the house call out loudly.

Shamane: Huh...he really wants me to die in those woods...

Shamane grumbles, but still washes the dagger clean in the basin, and turns to put out the fire.

"Creak-"

Pushing open the wooden door, a strong wind blasts in, blowing over many jars.

It's a gloomy autumn day; the skies are overcast, and the forest is steeped in gold.

Shamane: Phew— let's go.

# Bramble Bushes

COL-307227

A familiar place.

The thorn has expanded further, encompassing dozens of towering trees.

Spikes entwine the roots, nests on branches sealed off, feathers hooked on the spikes.

Shamane: Remember what happened when we first met?

Shamane: You nearly blinded one of my eyes.

Below, a gray rabbit is hooked by its skin, blood-staining its fur.

It's exhausted, no longer struggling.

Shamane: Hah, what a shame…I know how to deal with you now…

Shamane: I need to borrow…something from you.

He cuts his palm, blood dripping down, seeping into the soil.

Shamane: …

He lowers his head, deep syllables spilling from his throat.

The thorns sip the blood, slowly retreating like a snake back to its nest.

The spikes pull out of the rabbit, which quickly escapes.

A clear path appears ahead.

Shamane: Oh, thank you so much! Let me see… A flower crown… Hmm…can this be called such a thing?

Brushing aside dead leaves, he scans the exposed patches of earth.

"Crack."

Shamane: Hm…?

Lifting his foot, a withered ring of thorns, hardly worthy of being called a "crown", reveals itself.

Shamane: Oh well…didn't say it had to be intact, right?

# Giant Rock

COL-307228

Another old friend long unseen.

It sits here, enduring storms and invading winds. Despite the erosion of time, it doesn't budge an inch.

Stubborn, obstinate, rigid…indifferent to all criticism.

Shamane: Oh, you used to be…this small?

He raises his solitary arm, trying to measure its change.

Shamane: I remember back then, you were at least five, or six trees wide…

Shamane: Hah! After I left, you must've given quite some people headaches, big guy.

The boulder's surface is scarred all over—carved, burnt, pummeled…anything imaginable to get back at it.

Shamane: But I've grown some.

He touches the scars, lightly pressing his forehead against the hard boulder, and stepping back.

Then he kneels, bowing his head, letting his forehead sink deep into the damp soil, paying due reverence.

He hears the soil loosen, and the boulder rises from its haughty throne, shifting aside.

Shamane: Hah! Thank you, my proud friend.

Under the boulder's throne, a verdant plant is bent over, Shamane gently picks it.

# River

COL-307229

It remains, the pulse of the hills, ceaselessly night and day, dividing the land in two, like an insurmountable chasm.

The gurgling waters surge forth, even more turbulent than before.

Shamane: ♪—

Shamane steps barefoot into the river, steady as a boulder.

Shamane: Tch— It's so cold.

He slowly submerges into the icy river, until the waters pass over his head.

Shamane: ...

Inside the endlessly turbulent river, it's as tranquil as the womb.

Here, the ripples vanish, the bottom clearly visible.

The river tenderly receives Shamane, enveloping him.

Shamane: ...

This river was once called "Krupi". It's said those close to her can obtain her gifts on the riverbed.

He opens his eyes, below in the river. The glowing aquatic plants flourish, like stars in the water.

Shamane: @%$... <*Thank you...*>

Shamane reaches out, gently plucking one.

Shamane: Splash!

By the time he returns ashore, the waters are churning once again...

# Epilogue: It Rains the Same Old Rain

COL-307230

Eight! Shamane followed the bizarre old man for eight harsh winters.

But something changed in the third year after they met.

It was a stormy snowy night, and he held the wolf pup saved from the bear's belly, as if holding his past self in the flames.

Shamane: ...

—He thought he had shed all his tears.

But the heart-wrenching pain was merely swallowed and kept silent.

The fear of death is nothing more than a shield over a pair of eyes.

Until in the cold winds, drenched in blood, trembling...

He held the sole survivor.

And discovered fear and pain once more.

He dwelled with them again day and night.

Only this time he would no longer flee in defeat.

Shamane: Hmm...I think that's about everything.

Then, the taciturn shaman began teaching him all about nature.

He hadn't found life's meaning, but he no longer searched for one.

Shamane: As long as I keep going...keep moving forward...

The nightmares halted before his bed.

Shamane: Good—

Shamane stands at the forest entrance—he has one last item left.

Fine rain scrapes his face, the forest drizzling, and he quickens his steps.

3#1

# Prologue: Friendship with a Fluffball

COL-307231

It's far on the other side of the mountain, requiring him to first cross this dark, dense forest.

The rain intensifies, mud underfoot, his steps arduous.

This is an insignificant part of the penance. Compared to the unfathomable human heart...nature is harmonious.

Shamane: You might have sent your blessing to the wrong place. *pants*

He wipes away the rain blurring his vision, panting loudly to avoid sucking water up his nose.

The way ahead is still unclear, but at least this time he knows where to go.

# Overgrown Intersection

COL-307232

Shamane: Thorn grass... That's troublesome. Hopefully, it left me another path...

The grass, taller than his waist, forms a dense barrier.

Softened by the raindrops, it's bent at the waist. Once touched, the blades stiffen, their interwoven and razor-sharp edges able to cut skin to ribbons.

Faint sounds come from the thickets.

Shamane: Hey, little fellow, what are you doing here?

The rain has soaked the lamb's fur, head down, chewing on the thorn grass roots. Their tongue secretions can make the grass lower its defenses.

Shamane: Where are your friends?

It lifts its head, bleating, revealing a head missing an ear.

Shamane: ...!

Shamane: You are...

The ram collapses on the ground, panting and struggling. The wolf's sharp teeth deeply embedded in its flesh like a barbed hook.

Shaman: ...Don't go over.

Shamane releases the dagger in his hand, swallowing his voice, obediently backing into the bushes.

The elderly ram was isolated, which usually meant a gruesome ending.

Shamane: But it's your sheep...isn't it?

Shaman: No life should belong to me.

Shamane: ...

A sound rustles in the bushes.

Shaman: Crackle—

But instead of a foot, a...small lamb peeks out.

Shamane: !?

The lamb lifts its short horns, rushing at the wolf pack without hesitation and toppling over.

The pack retreats half a step, then surges forth again, gnawing the lamb's head, tearing its tender fur.

The bushes begin rustling once again, and the flock charges out, rushing at the wolves.

Shamane: ...Seeing you really makes me happy, friend.

He kisses its soft forehead.

Shamane: Twee-twee—...

His whistle pierces through the torrential rain, like an arrow shooting into the distant forest. After a brief silence, a group of Tahrs rushes over one after another.

They squeeze Shamane back, diligently chewing away the thorn grass. Soon, the barrier is cleared away.

Shamane: Yes...that's right...

# Carbuncle

COL-307233

In the gully, the river rises high, submerging the pebble road.

The formation is scattered by the rain, the furball hopping anxiously atop a tall rock.

Carbuncle: @#$%! @#$%!

It has no way out, the rapid waters surging beneath it.

Shamane: Stay there, don't move.

Shamane wades into the rapids and carries the furball off the rock.

Safe on land, it stares wide-eyed, looking curiously at the tall figure before it.

Shamane: Why are you all alone?

Carbuncle: &@#$%, $%@#——#$%!

Drenched, the furball scurries left and right, trying to explain. Realizing its futility, it pitifully stops and stands in place.

Shamane: Come on, follow me...

Shamane places it atop his head. The furball sways about, finding its balance, sitting steadily.

# Musk Deer

COL-307234

A cave appears ahead, pitch-black and unfathomable. Still, it's dry, and keeps out the chilling wind.

Shamane: Oh! Nature's gift!

Shamane leans in, wringing out his clothes.

He takes out a piece of flint and looks around, but the dry twigs on the ground are too brittle and wet. There's nothing that would easily ignite—well...not nothing...

Shamane: ...

He grabs the furball off his head, squeezing it in his hand. Fluffy, warm—and ignitable.

Carbuncle: ...

Carbuncle: @#$%!

The furball senses the danger.

Shamane: Hey, this is a good deal...

Shamane: It will be good for both of us to warm up!

The carbuncle clearly doesn't understand the negotiation, but it does feel the chill of the cave.

Carbuncle: @#$%!

The furball curses, turning around to reveal its long back fur.

Shamane: See, you're so considerate!

He reaches out, quickly and decisively pulling out a tuft—

Carbuncle: ——!

Thanks to its help, Shamane gets a fire going. Soon, the flames are blazing fiercely, radiating warmth.

The flames light the cave. A hulking figure staggers over, following the light.

??? : ...

Carbuncle: Waaa@#%!

The furball scurries behind Shamane's rear.

Shamane: This is...

Shamane stands, peering into the darkness.

The hulking figure struggles to stand—

—and crashes to the ground.

Shamane gently approaches, supporting the body and touching the wound on its neck, its breath weak and exhausted.

Shamane: ...I'm sorry.

The giant moose knows death is coming, like a slow, gentle nightfall. And this cave is its chosen resting place.

He gently holds up its head, easing its pain as much as possible.

Moose: …

He looks into its dimming eyes, feeling his palms gradually soaked in blood…

The stench of blood spreads, attracting wolves outside the cave.

Shamane: !?

Caught off guard, the alpha pounces, knocking Shamane to the ground.

The rest of the pack follows, pouncing together—

—Excitedly, they lick his face and warm palms.

Shamane: Enough. Now that's enough, my friends. Sit, sit.

Shamane: …I have something I still need to do.

He kneels by the moose.

Shamane: *A feast has been given to us.*

Shamane: *May it walk with you, mother nature.*

Footprints trace the cliff's edge, startling the birds into flight…becoming food, and nurturing new life.

Destruction precedes creation; death nurtures birth.

The wolves feast merrily, surrounding him like children, keeping him warm with their thick fur.

Right then and there, Shamane's stomach starts howling.

Carbuncle: @#$%!…

The furball glances up at him, staggering over with meat on its mouth.

The flames flicker as the wolves' snores rise and fall.

Outside the cave, the rain still falls.

# Epilogue: Friendship with a Fluffball

COL-307235

As dawn approaches, the torrential rain eases and mist shrouds the forest.

He leaves the cave early, heading towards the forest's edge.

Before long, the path ends and he is met by towering cliffs.

He looks down, another forest flourishing below, where the last herbs grow.

Shamane: Phew—! Wish me luck.

He climbs down the imposing cliffs tremulously.

A shadow blocks the sunlight.

Shamane: Hey, don't come down!

The furry creature leaps over, smacking him in the face.

Shamane: I—Must save—

The stones on the cliff can't bear their weight, falling alongside his shouts…

3#1

# Prologue: At the End of the Forest

COL-307236

Shamane opens his eyes, only to find the furball staring at him with its round eyes.

Shamane: You rascal, I only plucked some of your fur...

Shamane: You didn't have to go this far...

Carbuncle: @#%!

It grabs the herbs in its mouth, bouncing away.

Shamane: Hey, give that back. I'll pluck some of my own hair if I have to!

But before he finishes speaking, the fury thing blends into the bushes.

He gets up helplessly, bearing the pain, following it into the misty forest...

# Stone Tablet: One

COL-307237

Shamane: "All living beings, souls bound; from beasts to birds, from flowing waters to unyielding stones, all share an equal essence."

Shamane: "Kill and trample not; hold respect within."

He leans down, the carved lines on the stele ancient and too eroded to discern.

Shamane: These strokes.

He goes behind the stele, finding the surface blood-stained from long ago...

Carbuncle: @#%!

The furball ignores the stele, bounding ahead on its own.

# Stone Tablet: Two

COL-307238

Shamane: ...

He smells the mist, frowning.

Shamane: Smells like... mushrooms.

Danger lurks within—an instinct honed over months and years.

Brushing aside some weeds, another stele appears.

The stele is severely damaged, its carvings unrecognizable.

Shamane: "Life is ceaseless as the endless streams."

Shamane: "Those against nature shall suffer..."

Shamane: ...?

Hearing a crackling sound below, he shifts his foot, revealing the bone of a human hand.

# Stone Tablet: Three

COL-307239

Fungi cover the tree trunks, dense like swarming bees.

Sticky fluids seep from the dark green mushrooms, dripping onto withered plants.

Shamane: ...This place was nothing like this before...

Shamane: Something feels wrong... What is this strange place?

He carefully surveys the surroundings, finding a stele wrapped in cyst-like fungi.

Suppressing disgust, he pulls out the fungal bodies, revealing the carved lines on the stele.

Shamane: "Death and life, movement and stillness, all are one."

Shamane: "Thoughts and feelings are but ephemeral shells."

Shamane: ...

This is such an obvious warning.

Shamane: Sigh... I should've known this is another of the old man's traps!

But before entering the forest, it is pointless to question such things.

Shamane: Let's go. What else can we do but enter and look...

# Epilogue: At the End of the Forest: One

COL-307240

The carbuncle stops, excitedly showing him this...swamp.

At the forest's edge, a group of black carbuncles are grouped together, as if deep in discussion.

He realizes this is likely their former habitat.

Carbuncle: @#$!

Shamane: Oh, so you brought me to meet your little friends? Great... Otherwise, the old man would complain about having another mouth to feed.

As he approaches, the strange feeling intensifies...

Shamane: I say...your friends don't seem as chatty as you.

Shamane: Hmmm...this smell is quite rancid.

The rotten stench rushes up his nose, making him gag.

The furry creature's "friends" remain in place.

Shamane: Hey...I brought your friend back—

Shamane: !?

Touching them, the carbuncles roll down, revealing hollowed eye sockets.

Shamane: Little furball!

It jumps onto a rock in the swamp's center.

An orange plant entwined by mycelium sits on it. It's just what he's been looking for.

Carbuncle: @#$!

Shamane: Hey, be careful!

"Crack."

He looks down, and sees a broken shaman mask under his foot.

Shamane: ...Damn it.

Lifting his head, a hand suddenly flies out, dragging him into the swamp without a word...

# Epilogue: At the End of the Forest: Two

COL-307241

Shamane: Argh... Blargh...

Shamane: Give it...to me!

Dragging his battered body, he uses his last ounce of strength to ignite a piece of wood, hurling it into the heart of the fungus.

The fungi shriek as the flames scorch them, eventually turning to ashes.

Holding the plant in his arms, he crawls towards the exit on the ground.

Shamane: ...What?

The smell of burnt fungi invades his nose.

Shamane: Oh no...

A sourceless mist fills his mind like water, devouring his legs and gradually spreading to the tip of his nose...

His eyes grow veiled.

...

...

Carbuncle: ...

A black figure emerges in the mist.

Carbuncle: @#$&! @#$&!

Shamane: ...

A loner among the carbuncles, it has carried countless things across the neglected forest—

Fur damp, icicles hang from its frozen snot. The source of water in the harsh winters is the culprit for everyone's growling stomachs.

Sticky, delicious honeycombs that make one swell up painfully are the great lord's tribute.

And the huge, incessant rocks, tumbling down the tall slopes that harm it... Is that not their true purpose?

But this is the strangest thing it carries—a human. It is a warm and rather smelly creature.

**What is that? What is...that?**

It doesn't care.

Carbuncle: @#$&...

It carries the heavy body, climbing up like always...yet something is different.

Reaching the exit, the mist recedes, and light spills down.

It puts down the body. It's time ... to go back.

...

... .....

3#1

# Prologue: Dimming Embers

COL-307242

The uncrossable river, the impregnable thorns, the unyielding boulders... They come in waves...

Nature stands bare before you with no one avoiding its existence.

You must wade in and touch with your own hands... You retreat in fear, knowing its essence.

Only when shattered does a stubborn rock know its toughness.

Only when nearly extinguished can a flame understand its brightness.

Once again, he finds himself in the same place. He feels the scorching air and hears the cries and wails echoing as flames gradually consume the house.

Shamane: ...I haven't been back for a long time.

"I called you back here." The once familiar voice says.

"It's collapsing."

Shamane: ...

"This is the last time. I won't bring you back here again."

"You can leave as you wish. Nothing will hinder you."

**Choices**

1. ...Leave directly

2. I want to see them again.

**Branch 1**

"Ignore their cries and agony. See through the illusion and walk past it."

"Good luck."

**Branch 2**

"You sacrificed an arm. I'll pray for you."

"Good luck."

# Father

COL-307243

He is still lying by the corner, on his last breath.

Shamane: ...

He steps into the hall, standing before him, his shadow enveloping him.

This stubborn man shoulders the clan's burden, with no reprieve.

Now, his throat is unable to utter ringing rebukes; his calloused hands are no longer able to grip his son tightly.

As Shamane gazes upon his figure, it is a shadow of its former self.

Shamane: Father...

He gently lowers himself, placing his palm over the weathered hand.

Shamane's Father: ...

Shamane: I never succeeded in abandoning my guilt.

He looks at the aged face, yet it feels more like he is talking to himself.

Shamane: ...Yet, I failed to replace it with regret.

Shamane: I'm sorry ...

Shamane: To this day, my choice weighs on me.

He looks up, gripping his hand.

He doesn't try to pull him up. Rather, he just holds the old man tightly.

Shamane: I think I inherited your obstinacy...Father.

Shamane's Father: ...

Shamane's father embraces him, pulling him over and ruffling his hair.

He recalls such moments were commonplace before.

Shamane: ...

The father leans on his shoulder, lips trembling.

Shamane: ... Hm?

A heavy object is gently placed in his palm.

Shamane: This is your sister's...

Shamane: I understand.

Finally, weary yet reconciled, the old man lets go.

# Mother

COL-307244

Like a candle swaying in the wind, she sits by the servant's corpse, serenely awaiting the flames.

Shamane: Mother...

This face that once made him weep, these hands that held him up... now, they are just withered remains, her gaze dim, eyes empty.

He still doesn't know how to face her.

Shamane: ...

She looks up, gazing at this strong, grown child.

Her face reveals a familiar smile.

He goes forth, embracing her body as frail as withered leaves.

Who are they? If it was the past him, he would cling to this answer.

Shamane: You always...protected me...

That was the final barrier between her and her son—knowing the truth would only bring unknown danger.

Now he understands.

Shamane's Mother: You've grown taller, Pushya.

Shamane: Mother, I...

She gently nudges him to stand, helping him away from the sea of flames.

Her smiling face gradually blurs, until it completely disappears amidst the flames.

# Kumar

COL-307245

Like dusk in autumn, the sacred fig tree silently burns, the woman gazing at it under the tree for a long time.

Shamane: ...It brought you here too.

She remains silent.

He reaches out to the figure below, opening his palm. A moonstone ground smooth.

Shamane: Is this yours, sister?

Kumar raises her eyebrows slightly.

Kumar: ...Where did you get this?

Shamane: I think you know.

Shamane: He said "sorry" to me—he never says that.

Kumar takes the rounded stone, gently tossing it into the air.

Kumar: Huh...

She stands, holding the pebble for a bit. Turning, she wanders towards the flames.

Shamane: Where are you going...!

Shamane: He told me to bring you back...

Shamane: But I think...you should decide for yourself.

She waves casually in a perfunctory gesture, or perhaps bidding farewell.

Shamane: ...

Shamane: You deserve your freedom, my sister.

He murmurs to her as she departs.

# Epilogue: Dimming Embers

COL-307246

Going deeper into the sea of flames, the heat gradually dissipates. At the path's end, he sees a door enveloped in fire.

"This is the final stretch, Pushya."

"I will bid you farewell too."

Shamane: ...Why?

"I have protected every Sharma—but you shall no longer be one of them."

Shamane: ...What does that mean?

"You'll understand."

"You'll eventually know this is not an ill thing."

"...I'm very grateful for your choice back then. I did indeed take that arm."

"Now I must leave."

"Go on, child."

Shamane: ...

Shamane looks around, but the elephant has vanished without a trace.

He holds his breath, turning the handle, light spilling through the crack...

Shaman: You owe it gratitude for its protection.

Opening his eyes once more, he finds himself in the cabin, the alpha wolf at his bedside.

He sits up, pressing his dizzy head.

Shamane: What happened to me... Huh? Where is it? Where did it go?

Shaman: What are you talking about?

Shamane scans the room, trying to find the tiny black figure, but without success.

Shamane: That carbuncle, it should've been with me...

Shaman: The wolf carried you back here, with everything on your person, but no carbuncle, child.

Shamane: ...

As the alpha licks his hand, he feels an itch, realizing that his palm is gripping something tightly.

Opening his palm, he sees a tuft of fur.

He inhales, taking a deep breath.

The shaman rummages through his pocket and hands over an unopened letter.

Shaman: This was with you on the doorstep.

He takes the unopened letter, the pattern on the sealed wax one that emerged countless times in his dreams.

Frowning, the scene before him is bewildering—

Inside the envelope, the letter is blank.

Shamane: It's from...Mor Pankh?

3#2